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Getting Motoproponent to 1,000 subscribers

Written for Jeffrey, August 2026. The goal, in his words: **1,000 subscribers before 28 February 2031—retirement day.** That gives us about four and a half years. Here is the honest picture and what I would do about it.

The target is really two numbers, not one

To turn on ad revenue, YouTube asks for **1,000 subscribers *and* 4,000 hours of watch time in the previous 12 months.**

That second number is the one to pay attention to, because it works differently. Subscribers are cumulative—once someone subscribes, they count forever. Watch hours are a rolling twelve-month window that keeps moving, so hours you earn in 2027 have expired by 2029. You cannot bank them early. They have to be earned in the year leading up to the day you want to get paid.

So "we hit 1,000 subscribers" is not the same as "we can monetize." Worth knowing now rather than in 2030.

The subscriber half is the easy half

1,000 subscribers spread over 54 months is about **19 a month.** That is a genuinely modest number, and if the channel is doing anything at all it will get there.

4,000 watch hours in a single year is the real work. Put concretely: if a typical viewer watches six minutes of a video, that is roughly 40,000 views across the year. That is the target to actually plan around.

There is an earlier milestone worth aiming at first

Before full monetization, YouTube has a lower tier: **500 subscribers, 3,000 watch hours in 12 months, and 3 public uploads in the last 90 days.** It unlocks fan funding—memberships, Super Thanks, tips—but not ad revenue.

I would treat this as the real first goal. It arrives years sooner, it starts earning something, and you graduate to full monetization automatically without reapplying.

Longer videos, not Shorts

There is a Shorts route to monetization, but it needs 10 million Shorts views in 90 days. That is not a realistic path for this channel.

More importantly, Shorts views **do not count** toward the 4,000 watch hours. A viewer who watches twelve minutes of a touring video gives you twelve minutes. The same viewer flicking past three Shorts gives you almost nothing that counts. Your commuting vlogs, day trips and road trips are exactly the right format—lean into them.

Shorts still have a use: they are good at putting your face in front of strangers. Treat them as advertising for the long videos, never as the product.

Be findable, not just good

The biggest moto channels will beat you on production and on charisma. They will not beat you on the specific questions you can answer, because you actually live them: what an electric motorcycle is like as a daily commute, what the range really is, where you charge on a day trip out of the Bay Area, what a newcomer gets wrong.

Those are things people literally type into YouTube. A video that answers one of them keeps finding new viewers for years, long after a vlog has stopped. That is how the watch hours accumulate while you sleep. Every few videos, make one that answers a question rather than shares a ride.

Pick a schedule you can keep for four years

Four and a half years is a long time, and the most common way this fails is not bad videos—it is three months of enthusiasm followed by nothing. A video every two weeks that you actually sustain beats weekly for a month and then silence. YouTube also rewards consistency, and the 500-subscriber tier requires 3 uploads in any 90-day window, so lapsing has a real cost.

What the website is for

Do not expect the site to bring you subscribers. That is not its job.

Its job is to be the one link that always works and always sends people to the channel. It goes in your Instagram bio, your email signature, anywhere you introduce yourself. It also lets us see how many people are actually making the trip from Instagram to YouTube, which we cannot measure if you link the channel directly.

Instagram's job is finding strangers

Instagram is good at reach and terrible at sending people anywhere—it does not give you clickable links in captions. The only reliable path out is the link in your bio. So: **Instagram finds people, the bio link sends them to the site, the site sends them to the channel.**

One more thing, and it matters more than which platforms you pick: two accounts you actually feed beat five you abandon. A profile whose last post is a year old tells people the channel is dead. Stay on YouTube and Instagram until something forces a third.

Five things to do now

1. **Put** `motoproponent.com` **in your Instagram bio link.** Free, takes a minute, and it is the highest-value thing on this list.
2. **Add** `motoproponent.com` **as the first link on your YouTube channel** (Studio → Customization → Basic info → Links).
3. **Aim at 500 subscribers and 3,000 watch hours first**, not 1,000. Nearer, and it starts earning.
4. **Commit to an upload rhythm you can hold for four years**, and never let 90 days pass with nothing.
5. **Make one findable, question-answering video for every few ride videos.** Those are what still bring viewers in 2030.

Where these numbers come from

- YouTube Partner Program overview and eligibility
- Overview of the expanded YouTube Partner Program

YouTube has changed these thresholds before and may change them again. Worth a re-check once a year.